

THE SUN: FOREVER A SYMBOL OF HOPE

In recent years, our world has become increasingly unpredictable and volatile. Climate change is rapidly changing weather patterns, and global crises have put a heavy strain on energy, commercial fertilizer and global supply chains in general. The results of which have trickled down and disproportionately affected the most vulnerable in our communities.

Kanthasami Mallikathevi, is a small-scale woman farmer from Kirishnapram, Killinochchi, in the North of Sri Lanka. As a mother of three and the head of a household, she is extremely reliant on access to water and affordable electricity to ensure a bountiful harvest each season.

“We have four acres of land, but because electricity was so expensive, we could only cultivate a small portion of it”

During the height of the civil conflict that plagued the Island for over 3 decades, Mallikathevi and her family fled their ancestral home and lands in Killinochchi, to seek refuge in Vavuniya. After the war they returned home and have since struggled to rebuild their lives. As a woman living with a disability, she works side-by-side with her husband to manage their land — determined to provide for their family despite multiple vulnerabilities. With support from the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP) in Sri Lanka, through the ‘Empowering Women Smallholders Farmers through Renewable Energy-Based Agriculture Modernization Technologies’ project, funded by the Government of Japan through the Japanese Supplementary Budget (JSB), Mallikathevi received a solar-powered irrigation system. She is one of over a hundred beneficiaries who have received such systems that have been distributed in the Killinochchi District through the project.



“Because of this solar-powered irrigation system, our irrigation costs have reduced significantly, and now we are able to cultivate the entire land,”



Beneficiaries of the project were also provided with SHEP (Smallholder Horticulture Empowerment and Promotion) training, a Japanese methodology that empowers farmers to make informed, market-oriented decisions.

Under the SHEP approach, Mallikathevi took part in four structured training sessions focused on crop planning and marketing, helping her shift from simply growing crops to growing what the market demands. This was further reinforced through financial literacy capacity-building initiatives, delivered through training-of-trainers and beneficiary sessions, strengthening her ability to manage income and plan investments.

For the first time, the family has expanded into paddy cultivation, alongside vegetables. Reliable solar irrigation has improved growing conditions, reduced dependence on costly grid electricity, and enabled year-round planning — even under increasingly unpredictable climate conditions.



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Today, Mallikathevi's harvest serves multiple purposes. Her family consumes nutritious food, while surplus vegetables are sold to companies and supplied to schools, strengthening local food systems.



“Due to the increased vegetable production, we use some for our own consumption and sell the rest,” she explains. “By marketing our products to the companies, we earn a good income and our quality of life has increased significantly”.

This transition — from subsistence farming to market participation — reflects the project's broader goal: strengthening energy security, livelihoods, and human security for climate-vulnerable communities, particularly women smallholder farmers.

Across the Kilinochchi District, 100 solar irrigation systems have been deployed through the project, paired with structured training on sustainable agriculture, entrepreneurship, and financial management. These interventions are designed not only to support Sri Lanka's just transition toward net-zero pathways, but also to ensure that everyone is included and no one is left behind. For the Government of Japan and UNDP, human security lies at the heart of climate action — protecting lives, livelihoods, and dignity in the face of global crises. Mallikathevi's journey illustrates how targeted investments in renewable energy can restore agency to communities rebuilding after conflict, while equipping them to face the climate challenges ahead.



In Kirishnapuram, the scorching sun is no longer an additional burden, to the many communities that struggle with poverty, scarcity and mostly a lack of hope—it has become a source of security, and resilience.